EGGLESS NUTELLA CHOCOLATE LAVA CAKES

Six individual gourmet cakes • Frozen Nutella ganache core • Rich, molten centre

Yield	Ramekins	Oven	Bake
6 cakes	180–200 ml	190°C conventional	11–14 minutes

Recipe concept

This version uses a separately prepared, frozen Nutella–chocolate ganache insert. The insert stays in the centre while the eggless chocolate cake bakes around it, creating a reliable molten filling without relying on underbaked raw batter. The key controls are a fully frozen insert, complete batter coverage and careful baking.

1. Frozen Nutella ganache inserts

Ingredient	Quantity
Nutella	180 g
Dark couverture chocolate, 55–60%, finely chopped	45 g
Heavy cream (approximately 35% fat)	35 g
Unsalted butter	10 g
Fine sea salt	0.5 g

Method

1. Place the chopped chocolate in a heatproof bowl. Warm the cream until steaming, then pour it over the chocolate. Leave undisturbed for 30 seconds. Stir from the centre outwards until a smooth ganache forms.
2. Stir in the Nutella until completely emulsified. Add the butter and salt; mix until glossy and uniform.
3. Portion into six equal inserts of approximately 45 g each, using a small silicone mould. Freeze for 2–3 hours, or until completely firm. Keep frozen until assembly.

2. Eggless chocolate cake batter

Ingredient	Quantity
Dark couverture chocolate, 60–65%, chopped	150 g
Unsalted butter	100 g
Nutella	100 g
Caster sugar	65 g
Light brown sugar	35 g
Full-fat sour cream, room temperature	100 g
Whole milk	45 g
Vanilla bean paste or extract	5 g
Plain flour	75 g
Dutch-process cocoa powder	18 g
Cornflour	10 g
Skimmed milk powder	8 g
Baking powder	2 g
Fine sea salt	1.5 g
Espresso powder	1 g

Method

1. Melt the butter gently in a saucepan or heatproof bowl. Remove from the heat, add the chopped couverture and stir until smooth. Mix in the Nutella.
2. In a separate bowl, whisk the sour cream, caster sugar, brown sugar, milk and vanilla until smooth and the sugars begin to dissolve.
3. Gradually whisk the warm chocolate mixture into the sour-cream mixture in a thin stream. Mix until glossy and uniform; do not add it all at once while very hot.
4. Sift together the flour, cocoa, cornflour, milk powder, baking powder, salt and espresso powder. Fold into the wet mixture in two additions with a silicone spatula. Stop as soon as no dry flour remains. The batter should be thick, smooth and glossy.

3. Prepare the ramekins and assemble

You will need six 180–200 ml oven-safe ramekins. Brush the base and sides thoroughly with softened butter. Dust lightly with cocoa powder, tapping out the excess. Chill the prepared ramekins for 10 minutes if your kitchen is warm.

Assembly for each ramekin

Ingredient	Quantity
Chocolate cake batter – base layer	60 g
Frozen Nutella insert	1 piece, approx. 45 g
Chocolate cake batter – top layer	59 g

1. Add 60 g batter to each ramekin and spread into an even layer.
2. Unmould one completely frozen insert and place it in the centre. Keep it away from the sides.
3. Cover with approximately 59 g batter. Seal the insert completely, including around its edges; no part of the frozen filling should remain exposed.
4. Smooth the surface gently. Bake promptly, or refrigerate the assembled ramekins briefly while the oven finishes preheating. Do not allow the frozen inserts to thaw.

4. Bake and unmould

Preheat a conventional oven to 190°C. Place the ramekins on a sturdy baking tray and bake for approximately 11–14 minutes. The edges should look set and the tops should have lost their wet shine, while the centre remains soft. Ovens and ramekin materials vary, so bake one test cake first. If the centre collapses or the cake cannot be unmoulded, add 1 minute to the next test; if the filling is not molten, reduce the bake slightly.

Rest for 1–2 minutes. Run a thin palette knife around the edge, place a serving plate over the ramekin and invert carefully. Lift the ramekin away. Serve immediately; the molten centre thickens as it cools.

5. Warm Nutella chocolate sauce

Ingredient	Quantity
Nutella	120 g
Dark couverture chocolate	50 g
Heavy cream	100 g
Whole milk	30 g
Unsalted butter	15 g
Fine sea salt	0.5 g

Warm the cream and milk until steaming. Pour over the chopped chocolate and leave for 30 seconds. Stir from the centre until smooth. Add Nutella, butter and salt; stir until glossy. Keep warm, not hot. If it thickens, loosen with a little warm milk.

6. Plating and service

Spoon approximately 35–40 g warm sauce onto each plate or around the base of the cake. Set the lava cake on top. Finish with toasted chopped hazelnuts, dark chocolate shavings and a few flakes of sea salt. A small scoop of vanilla ice cream is an excellent optional contrast. Serve at once, while the centre is flowing.

Professional control points

• **Freeze the inserts hard.** A soft insert smears into the batter during assembly and is less likely to remain distinct.

• **Use couverture for the best texture.** Compound chocolate can set differently and may produce a waxier ganache.

• **Keep the insert centred and sealed.** Contact with the ramekin wall can cause leakage and uneven baking.

• **Do not overmix after adding flour.** Fold only until the flour disappears to avoid a tough cake.

• **Calibrate your oven.** The 11–14 minute range is a starting point; ramekin thickness, fill temperature and oven accuracy all affect the result. Test one cake before baking the full batch.

• **Serve immediately.** This dessert is designed for service straight after unmoulding; holding it will reduce the molten effect.

Make-ahead, storage and reheating

The ganache inserts can be made ahead and kept frozen in an airtight container. The cake batter is best mixed shortly before assembly. Assembled, unbaked ramekins may be covered and refrigerated briefly, but the bake time will need checking because the batter and insert will be colder. Baked cakes are not ideal for reheating: the centre will not reliably return to its original molten texture. For service, bake to order.

Troubleshooting

Filling leaks: the insert was not fully covered, was placed too close to the ramekin wall, or had softened before baking.
Cake sticks: the ramekin was inadequately buttered/cocoa-dusted, or the cake was inverted too soon.
Centre is fully set: bake time was too long, the insert was too small, or the oven ran hot. Reduce the next test by 1 minute.
Cake collapses: the outer structure was underbaked. Increase the next test by 1 minute and allow a 1–2 minute rest before unmoulding.

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